

LIBERTY CYBER THREAT INTELLIGENCE

THE ALAMO THREAT BRIEF™

OPEN SOURCE INTELLIGENCE

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Executive decision intelligence for Texas critical infrastructure.

This issue of the **Alamo Threat Brief** aligns to the week of **13 April 2026** and assesses a threat environment shaped by simultaneous pressure from **Iranian OT disruption, PRC pre-positioning, DPRK financial theft, and industrialized ransomware targeting**—each tied to larger geopolitical dynamics that are increasing cyber risk to Texas organizations. The central analytic judgment is that Texas organizations are no longer managing isolated cyber risk. They are operating inside an interconnected battlespace where disruption in **energy, healthcare, finance, and the defense industrial base** can cascade quickly across the state.

Decision 1 — OT Exposure

If you operate energy, water, industrial, or petrochemical infrastructure, decide this week whether you will disconnect or hard-segment any internet-reachable Rockwell / Allen-Bradley environment. If you do nothing, you are accepting a live disruption risk — not a theoretical one.

Decision 2 — Trusted Access

If you rely on vendors, SaaS, MSPs, telecoms, or identity platforms, decide whether those relationships are verified strongly enough to survive compromise. The most likely business-impact event is now a trusted-path failure, not a noisy perimeter breach.

Decision 3 — Business Continuity

If one critical dependency failed tonight, decide whether your leadership team knows which operations break first, how fast cash flow is affected, and who owns the response. If you cannot answer that in one page, you are underprepared for this environment.

CENTERPIECE ANALYSIS

The most important insight this week is not any one adversary. It is the **convergence** of multiple capable actors applying pressure at the same time, through different access vectors, for different strategic purposes. Iran is demonstrating a willingness to generate **real-world operational effects** against OT systems. China continues to maintain **quiet, durable access** inside U.S. critical infrastructure while avoiding premature activation. North Korea is proving it can generate strategic-scale revenue through **high-speed financial theft**. Meanwhile, ransomware groups are exploiting the same gaps in identity, patching, and vendor trust that state actors use for access.

For Texas, this matters more than it does in most states because the state combines **ERCOT, Gulf Coast petrochemicals, the Texas Medical Center, major financial hubs, and one of the densest defense and cyber ecosystems in the country**. A successful operation against one sector is no longer a contained event. It can become a cascading business and public-safety problem within hours.

Bottom line: executives should stop asking whether they are likely to be targeted. The more urgent question is whether they would recognize compromise early enough to preserve decision space once disruption begins.

Section I

Key Judgments

KJ-1

Liberty CTI assesses with **HIGH CONFIDENCE** that Iranian-affiliated cyber actors are **almost certainly** expanding disruptive OT targeting against U.S. energy and water infrastructure, and that **Texas falls into the highest-risk tier** because of its concentration of Gulf Coast petrochemical, utility, and water treatment environments. **HIGH CONFIDENCE**

Source basis / uncertainty: Primary uncertainty: open reporting does not yet identify Texas victims by name. That does not materially reduce the warning value for operators using exposed or weakly segmented Rockwell / Allen-Bradley environments.

KJ-2

Liberty CTI assesses with **HIGH CONFIDENCE** that PRC Typhoon actors **very likely** retain dormant access inside U.S. critical infrastructure and telecommunications ecosystems, and that the greatest near-term danger for Texas is not immediate disruption but **silent compromise that reduces warning time in a future crisis**. **HIGH CONFIDENCE**

Source basis / uncertainty: Primary uncertainty: Texas-specific dwell time and access points are not publicly quantified. The broader national pattern is sufficiently established to justify defensive hunting now.

KJ-3

Liberty CTI assesses with **HIGH CONFIDENCE** that DPRK financial cyber operations will **almost certainly** continue at scale through 2026 and that Texas financial institutions with crypto, fintech, or DeFi-adjacent exposure face **elevated third-party and integration risk**. The Drift theft demonstrated that DPRK actors can execute nine-figure thefts at machine speed once access is established. **HIGH**

CONFIDENCE

Source basis / uncertainty: Primary uncertainty: direct Texas victimization in this cycle is not yet public. Exposure is currently strongest through partners, platforms, and vendors rather than only through traditional banking cores.

KJ-4

Liberty CTI assesses with **MODERATE CONFIDENCE** that ransomware actors will **likely** increase supply-chain and identity-first attacks against Texas healthcare and DIB targets through Q2 and Q3 2026, compressing time between vulnerability disclosure and operational impact. **MODERATE CONFIDENCE**

Source basis / uncertainty: Primary uncertainty: timing and initial access vectors will vary by operator. The dominant pattern, however, is shifting away from perimeter-only compromise and toward trusted admin, vendor, and cloud pathways.

Decision implication: Healthcare and DIB leaders should treat vendor-access review and privileged-identity hardening as immediate business resilience actions, not backlog items.

KJ-5

Liberty CTI assesses with **MODERATE CONFIDENCE** that reduced federal cyber capacity will **likely** increase the intelligence and response burden on private organizations, raising the value of commercial warning, internal detection maturity, and direct state-level coordination for Texas decision-makers. **MODERATE CONFIDENCE**

Source basis / uncertainty: Primary uncertainty: the final scale and timing of federal resource reductions remain fluid. The direction of travel is still clear enough to matter for planning.

Decision implication: Executives should assume less federal warning and more self-reliance, then budget accordingly for internal detection, external intelligence, and response capacity.

Section II

What Happened This Week

Iran — OT Disruption Has Crossed from Warning to Confirmed Effect

A rare joint advisory from FBI, CISA, NSA, EPA, DOE, and U.S. Cyber Command confirmed that Iranian-affiliated actors have been exploiting internet-exposed Rockwell Automation and Allen-Bradley PLC environments to generate real-world disruption across U.S. critical infrastructure. That matters because it signals intent to move beyond access and reconnaissance toward **direct operational effects**. For Texas, where OT density is unusually high across utilities, petrochemicals, and water systems, this is the week's most important development.

CRITICAL INTELLIGENCE WARNING

Liberty CTI assesses that any Texas operator still treating exposed PLCs as a routine hardening issue is misreading the environment. For Allen-Bradley-heavy environments, this is now an **active threat condition**, not a planning scenario.

China — Pre-Positioning Remains the Core PRC Risk

PRC Typhoon operations continue to point to a doctrine of quiet access, infrastructure persistence, and crisis-contingency preparation. Volt Typhoon's LOTL tradecraft remains significant precisely because it is difficult to detect with traditional malware-centric security stacks. Salt Typhoon's telecom compromise reinforces a second-order risk that many executives still underestimate: **communications themselves**

may be observable even when networks appear normal.

ASSESSMENT

The most dangerous PRC cyber outcome in the near term is not a visible outage. It is the persistence of unseen access that strips away warning time when geopolitical tension spikes.

Russia / Ransomware — Texas Remains in the Blast Radius of a Mature Criminal Ecosystem

Ransomware remains a top operational threat to Texas healthcare, government-adjacent, and manufacturing targets because the ecosystem now scales through supply-chain and identity compromise faster than many organizations patch or validate trust relationships. The broader lesson is that criminal operators are exploiting the same structural weaknesses that nation-state actors value: **weak vendor governance, brittle identity controls, and uneven segmentation.**

DPRK — Financial Theft Has Become a Strategic Capability

DPRK's Lazarus ecosystem continues to treat cyber theft as state finance. The Drift Protocol theft underscored how little time defenders may have once access is established and approvals are manipulated. Texas-based financial institutions do not need to be crypto-native to care. The practical exposure runs through fintech partnerships, vendor integrations, software development pipelines, and any organization touching digital-asset infrastructure or adjacent services.

Section III

Geopolitical Drivers & Cyber Implications

Iran — Active Conflict Dynamics Are Increasing Cyber Risk to U.S. Infrastructure

What Happened: The current threat environment is being shaped by a broader escalation cycle involving Iran, regional proxy activity, maritime pressure, and direct friction with the United States and its partners.

Why It Matters: Iran uses cyber as an asymmetric instrument when it wants to impose costs, signal resolve, or retaliate without inviting an immediate conventional response. In that model, cyber is not secondary. It is one of the regime's most practical tools for coercion.

Cyber Implication: The confirmed exploitation of Rockwell Automation and Allen-Bradley PLC environments is consistent with Iranian intent to move beyond reconnaissance and into disruptive effect. Liberty CTI assesses that Iran is using cyber to create pressure against U.S. critical infrastructure while preserving ambiguity and limiting escalation thresholds.

Business Risk (Texas Lens): For Texas, this raises direct concern for energy, water, petrochemical, and industrial operators whose OT environments are exposed, weakly segmented, or dependent on trusted remote access. Texas is not just economically relevant in this context. It is one of the most operationally meaningful target environments in the country.

ASSESSMENT

Iran is the actor most likely to convert geopolitical tension into real-world disruption against Texas industrial systems.

China — Strategic Competition Is Driving Quiet Access, Not Immediate Disruption

What Happened: U.S.-China competition continues across semiconductors, AI, export controls, military posture in the Indo-Pacific, and telecommunications security. These are not isolated disputes. They are part of a larger strategic contest over technological and geopolitical advantage.

Why It Matters: Beijing's cyber behavior reflects long-term planning. China does not need to cause visible disruption now to create strategic value. Persistent access inside infrastructure and telecom environments gives it decision advantage later, especially in a crisis tied to Taiwan or wider U.S.-China confrontation.

Cyber Implication: Volt Typhoon and related PRC operations should be understood as contingency preparation. Salt Typhoon's telecom compromise reinforces a second, often underappreciated reality: China is not just targeting systems. It is targeting the information environment leaders rely on to make decisions.

Business Risk (Texas Lens): Texas sits at the intersection of energy infrastructure, AI buildout, defense concentration, and major telecommunications dependence. That makes the state highly relevant to PRC collection and pre-positioning logic, particularly where operational continuity, logistics, and communications overlap.

ASSESSMENT

The greatest PRC risk in Texas is not a sudden outage tomorrow. It is that quiet access today reduces your warning time in a future crisis.

Russia — Protracted Conflict Continues to Fuel Spillover and Criminal Pressure

What Happened: Russia's war in Ukraine remains a long-duration geopolitical driver shaping cyber behavior across both state and criminal ecosystems. Sanctions, confrontation with the West, and sustained wartime pressure continue to reinforce Moscow's reliance on asymmetric tools.

Why It Matters: Russia benefits from a permissive criminal ecosystem that can generate disruption, revenue, and strategic friction below the threshold of formal state attribution. Even when attacks are financially motivated, the broader environment still serves Russian interests by imposing cost and uncertainty on Western institutions.

Cyber Implication: Ransomware and criminal compromise should not be treated as disconnected from the geopolitical environment. Texas organizations remain exposed to a mature Russia-based ecosystem that can scale through supply chain, credential abuse, and identity compromise faster than many enterprises can respond.

Business Risk (Texas Lens): Healthcare, manufacturing, municipal, and government-adjacent entities in Texas remain exposed to high-volume operational disruption, particularly where vendor concentration and weak identity assurance create shared pathways across multiple organizations.

ASSESSMENT

Russia does not need a Texas-specific campaign to create Texas-specific damage. Spillover, tolerated criminal activity, and indirect pressure are enough.

DPRK — Regime Finance Requirements Are Sustaining High-Tempo Cyber Theft

What Happened: North Korea remains under heavy sanctions pressure and continues to rely on illicit finance to support regime survival, weapons development, and broader state priorities.

Why It Matters: For DPRK, cyber theft is not opportunistic side activity. It is a strategic revenue model. That means financial cyber operations will remain persistent, adaptive, and disciplined so long as they continue producing returns.

Cyber Implication: The Drift Protocol theft fits a long-standing North Korean pattern: patient access, rapid execution, and monetization at scale. Liberty CTI assesses that DPRK actors will continue prioritizing financial and crypto-adjacent pathways, including third-party platforms, software ecosystems, and workforce infiltration opportunities.

Business Risk (Texas Lens): Texas financial institutions, fintechs, crypto-adjacent firms, and software-enabled financial service providers are exposed less through headline bank compromise and more through integrations, vendors, developer environments, and trusted service relationships.

ASSESSMENT

If your business touches money, digital assets, payment infrastructure, or remote technical labor, DPRK activity is part of your threat model.

Section IV

Texas Sector Implications

Energy SEVERE

Primary risk: Iranian OT disruption layered over PRC pre-positioning.

Why Texas is exposed: ERCOT's isolation, Gulf Coast industrial density, LNG export infrastructure, and heavy Rockwell / Allen-Bradley footprint make Texas one of the most operationally consequential energy target sets in the country.

Executive implication: Treat exposed OT, weak IT/OT segmentation, and incomplete anomaly detection as active business continuity vulnerabilities — not just security debt.

Killer line: Texas grid isolation means there is no easy outside recovery path if a serious disruption lands here.

â™Ÿ Healthcare SEVERE	Primary risk: Ransomware and destructive misuse of legitimate IT management tooling. Why Texas is exposed: The Texas Medical Center and regional systems combine high operational pressure, sensitive data, shared vendors, and service continuity requirements that favor extortion actors. Executive implication: A single vendor or identity compromise can become a clinical operations problem quickly. Recovery readiness matters as much as prevention. Killer line: In healthcare, cyber risk now threatens care timelines, not just data.
ðŸ’° Finance HIGH	Primary risk: DPRK theft through integrations, vendors, and digitally enabled financial pathways. Why Texas is exposed: Texas combines large banking, insurance, and fintech ecosystems with growing digital-asset adjacency and third-party dependency. Executive implication: The highest-value question is no longer only “can our bank be hacked?” It is “which partner or platform could become the access vector into us?” Killer line: Third-party risk is now the front door to financial disruption.
ðŸ›¡ Defense / DIB HIGH	Primary risk: PRC espionage, telecom compromise, and identity / workforce infiltration. Why Texas is exposed: JBSA, Port San Antonio, and the broader DIB ecosystem create a dense environment of cleared personnel, contractors, telecom dependence, and sensitive technical data. Executive implication: Communications security, vendor assurance, and workforce validation are strategic controls here — not merely compliance exercises. Killer line: A telecom compromise can become a defense problem long before anyone sees malware.

AI / Data
Centers
ELEVATED

Primary risk: Cascading exposure through power dependency, cloud concentration, and developer-focused intrusion pathways.

Why Texas is exposed: Texas's AI and data-center buildout increases energy dependence and creates high-value digital concentration points that can amplify disruption elsewhere.

Executive implication: AI infrastructure should be treated as a cross-sector dependency, not a standalone technology niche. **Killer line:** Texas data-center growth is creating concentration risk faster than most companies are measuring it.

Section V

Priority Intelligence Requirements (PIRs)

PIR-1 Are Texas energy and water OT operators already inside the current Iranian targeting cycle?

[â†‘ RISING]

- Unexpected PLC project file changes or HMI/SCADA display anomalies
- Rockwell / Allen-Bradley devices reachable from public networks
- Unexplained OT access attempts or authentication events since March 2026
- Utility, municipal water, or Gulf Coast industrial disruption reporting with unclear technical cause

The national advisory confirms active disruption and validated OT intent. The open-source gap is victim identification, not campaign existence.

PIR-2 Do Texas organizations retain undetected PRC LOTL access in critical environments? [â†‘

RISING]

- Unusual use of native admin tools such as WMI, PowerShell, and netsh
- Edge device configuration changes without approved change control
- Low-volume outbound administrative traffic during non-business hours
- Communications anomalies across major telecom-dependent executive workflows

PRC access persistence is assessed as a strategic warning problem. The core issue is whether defenders are looking for the right artifacts.

PIR-3 Where is Texas financial exposure to DPRK theft most likely to emerge first? [? UNCLEAR]

- New or poorly vetted fintech and DeFi service integrations
- Suspicious developer recruitment or contractor sourcing behavior
- Third-party access requests into sensitive financial workflows
- Vendor-side compromise with potential access to transaction or identity systems

Direct victimization is not yet public. The highest-probability access path is through fintech, crypto-adjacent, and software integration ecosystems.

PIR-4 Will ransomware in Texas continue to scale through identity and vendor compromise rather than direct perimeter attacks? [â†‘ RISING]

- Shared SaaS, MSP, or healthcare IT vendor incident notifications
- Credential abuse against privileged or remote administrative accounts
- Rapid exploitation following newly public proof-of-concept releases
- Multiple Texas organizations impacted by a single upstream provider event

Recent patterns strongly support this shift. The question is no longer whether this model works, but which shared vendor becomes the next amplifier.

Section VI

Indicators to Watch — Next 2–4 Weeks

01 Texas-specific OT victim identification in federal, state, or media reporting connected to the current Iranian campaign.

02 Allen-Bradley / Rockwell anomaly reporting from Texas utility, petrochemical, or water environments.

03 Telecom or edge-device compromise details that sharpen Salt Typhoon's operational impact for executive communications.

04 Additional DPRK thefts against DeFi, fintech, or exchange-linked ecosystems that suggest widening target logic.

05 Texas healthcare vendor breach notifications that could propagate across multiple institutions at once.

06 Ransomware claims naming Texas hospitals, municipalities, or manufacturers tied to a shared access vector.

07 New federal or state warning products reflecting reduced response capacity or increasing burden on private operators.

08 Geopolitical escalation with Iran or a Taiwan-linked crisis signal that would raise the probability of cyber effects in Texas infrastructure.

Section VII

Executive Implications & Recommended Actions

1 — Reevaluate Exposure to OT and Remote Access

If you run industrial or utility-adjacent operations, confirm what is internet-reachable, what can be remotely administered, and what would fail if trust in those systems collapsed. **What happens if you get this wrong:** downtime, safety pressure, and urgent leadership decisions under degraded visibility.

2 — Validate Your Top Five Dependencies

Map the vendors, telecom paths, identity platforms, cloud services, and payment or billing partners that keep operations running. **What happens if you get this wrong:** you discover your real risk through another company's outage instead of your own planning.

3 — Shift Detection Toward Trust and Identity

Prioritize privileged access, vendor sessions, MDM tooling, telecom exposure, and unusual use of native admin tools. **What happens if you get this wrong:** a low-noise compromise survives long enough to become a board-level continuity issue.

4 — Budget for Less Federal Cushion

Assume more of your early warning and response burden will sit with your organization and state-level relationships. **What happens if you get this wrong:** slower detection, slower coordination, and higher business impact when incidents unfold.

Section VIII

Analyst's Note

ANALYST'S NOTE

What matters most this week is the loss of sequencing. Texas organizations once had the luxury of looking at Iran, China, DPRK, and ransomware actors as mostly separate problems. That is no longer a useful frame. Iran is applying pressure at the OT layer. China is shaping the strategic environment through persistence and communications compromise. DPRK is extracting capital from the financial layer. Criminal actors are exploiting the same trust relationships all of them rely on.

This convergence changes the operating logic for leaders. It means that resilience must be cross-sector, not just technical. It means boards need to understand dependency mapping, not only cyber maturity scores. It means executive communications are part of the threat surface. And it means that a Texas company can be “not directly targeted” and still be operationally affected through a partner, a utility dependency, or a telecom compromise.

The practical question for leadership is simple: **if one trusted system failed tonight — a utility connection, a hospital vendor, a telecom carrier, an identity platform, or a financial integration — how much time would we have before the problem became a business continuity decision?** Most organizations still do not know that answer with enough precision.

Section IX — Sourcing

Source Notes

OPEN SOURCE BASIS — ATB-2026-5 — UPDATED FOR THE WEEK OF 13 APRIL 2026

Federal Iranian PLC exploitation advisory

[EPA advisory release](#)

FortiClient EMS active exploitation reporting

[Article](#)

DPRK Drift Protocol theft and blockchain analysis

[Article](#)

Storm-1175 / Medusa ransomware reporting

[Article](#)

Flowise AI platform exploitation reporting

[Article](#)

Commercial threat intelligence and state reporting

[CrowdStrike report](#)

TORCH FUSION CYCLE

WHAT: Iran is producing confirmed OT disruption; PRC actors retain quiet access and telecom visibility; DPRK is accelerating strategic-scale financial theft; ransomware ecosystems are scaling through identity and supplier trust. **WHO:** IRGC-linked actors, Volt / Salt Typhoon clusters, Lazarus ecosystem, and Russia-based ransomware operators. **WHY:** Coercion, crisis preparation, sanctions evasion, and monetized disruption. **WHAT NEXT:** Texas organizations should expect persistent multi-actor pressure, shorter warning windows, and growing cross-sector dependency risk through Q2 and Q3 2026.

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